

Illinois Kei Vehicle Registration

What Illinois Residents Need to Know

The Issue in Plain English

Illinois is currently treating lawfully imported kei vehicles as 'off-highway' vehicles, which means owners cannot register them for normal road use. This is not because the vehicles were illegally imported, and not because owners failed inspection or insurance requirements. It is based on how Illinois is interpreting 625 ILCS 5/3-401(c-1).

Why This Is Happening

Under federal law, vehicles that are 25 years old or older may be legally imported into the United States under established federal pathways. However, Illinois registration is controlled at the state level. The Secretary of State has cited 625 ILCS 5/3-401(c-1), which restricts registration eligibility based on how a vehicle was originally manufactured for highway use. The current interpretation treats that phrase as meaning 'manufactured for U.S. highways.'

What This Means for Residents

Registrations have been denied or revoked. Titles have been branded 'Not Eligible for Registration.' Some owners have been instructed to surrender license plates. Contesting a decision requires a formal administrative hearing and filing fee.

What This Is NOT About

This is not about weakening safety laws or bypassing insurance requirements. Illinois would continue to enforce equipment requirements, insurance requirements, titling documentation, and traffic laws. The request is simply for normal registration eligibility.

The Narrow Fix

The General Assembly can clarify that a vehicle originally manufactured for highway use in any jurisdiction, and legally importable under federal law, may be titled and registered in Illinois under normal road-use conditions. This preserves enforcement authority while resolving ambiguity in 625 ILCS 5/3-401(c-1).

Why This Matters

Clear law protects residents. When statutory language is ambiguous, regular people absorb the consequences. This issue is about fairness, predictability, and consistent application of Illinois law.

What You Can Do

- Contact your Illinois State Representative and State Senator.
- Ask them to support a narrow statutory clarification to 625 ILCS 5/3-401(c-1).
- Encourage them to meet with the Secretary of State's office to confirm language that resolves the ambiguity while preserving safety and insurance requirements.